

A CORPUS-BASED INVESTIGATION OF LEARNER DISCUSSIONS ON THE PRONUNCIATION OF “THREE”

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Pronunciation is one of the most important and challenging aspects of second language acquisition. For English learners, difficulty often arises with pronouncing some consonant clusters or unfamiliar phonemes. The “th” or /θ/ sound may be challenging for learners to pronounce because it comes with an interdental fricative and, as such, may be substituted with “f” or “t”. For instance, “three” may be pronounced as “free” or “tree”.

Online language learning communities are a growing means of practising and mastering a language. They thus provide a means of understanding challenges learners face. They also provide a means of observing how learners and speakers collaborate to tackle these challenges through explanations, advice and practice tips.

This study applies Corpus Linguistics techniques to analyse how pronunciation difficulties are handled in an online English learning environment. It uses LancsBox to analyse articulatory explanations, discourse strategies and recurring lexical patterns, used in the pronunciation of the word “three”.

2.0 DATA

The dataset was obtained from an online English-learning community, where learners discussed the difficulty of pronouncing the word “three”. The data can be accessed here https://www.reddit.com/r/EnglishLearning/comments/1rs27za/pronouncing_three/. The data contains approximately 1300 words spread across several texts. The discussions were saved in several text files. Then, with the aid of the LancsBox corpus, linguistic techniques such as frequency analysis, concordance analysis (KWIC), and n-gram selection were carried out.

3.0 METHODOLOGY

The methods used for analysis in this study include:

- **Frequency Analysis:**
- Word frequency lists were generated to identify the most common lexical items appearing in the discussion. This helps identify the main topics and linguistic focus of the corpus.

- **Concordance Analysis (KWIC):** Keyword-in-context (KWIC) analysis was used to examine how “three” appears in different contexts. This method allows researchers to observe patterns of usage and recurring discourse structures.
- **N-gram Analysis:** Frequent two-word and three-word sequences were extracted to identify common expressions and explanatory phrases used when discussing pronunciation.
- Lastly, discourse markers expressing personal stance were analysed to observe how speakers frame their explanations and advice.

4.0 RESULTS

4.1 Frequency analysis

The following words were most frequently used in the discussion.

Value	Frequency
Tree	16
Three	12
Free	9
Teeth	8
English	7
Problem	4
Learners	1

Table 1: Frequency Analysis

The words “tree”, “three” and “free” appear the most in the discussion, showing that the conversation remained focused on the word pronunciation. “tree” had the highest frequency, indicating that it might be a comfortable substitute for English learners. Also, the presence of the word teeth suggests that many explanations involve articulatory descriptions, particularly those related to tongue and teeth positioning when producing the /θ/ sound. Note that prepositions, articles and conjunctions were not accounted for in this analysis as they do not contribute to the semantic profile of the discourse. Also, only keywords relating to pronunciation are highlighted from the analysis

4.2 Opinion markers

The corpus was also analysed for opinion markers, as shown below.

Expression	Frequency
I think	3
I feel	1

Table 2: Opinion Markers

The opinion markers observed in the discussion illustrate that the participants gave personal views rather than authoritative statements. It also shows the conversation was collaborative or conversational.

4.3 Frequent 2-word expressions

The frequency of 2-word expressions (2-grams) showed an explanatory discussion as shown below.

Word 1	Word 2	Frequency
Your	Tongue	10
The	Th	7
Is	To	6
Th	Sound	6
Instead	Of	5
You	Can	4
The	Word	4
In	The	4
Sound	In	4

Table 3: Frequency of 2-grams

The most frequent phrase, “your tongue”, indicates that participants frequently describe tongue placement when explaining how to produce the sound /θ/. Similarly, phrases such as “the th” and “th sound” show explicit discussion of phonetic features.

4.4 Frequent 3-word expressions

The analysis of 3-word expressions (3-grams) also highlighted that the discussion was explanatory.

Phrase	Frequency
The th sound	4
Free or three	3
The tip of	3
Tip of your	3
Of your tongue	3
The mouth movements	2

Table 4: Frequency of 2-grams

Phrases like “the th sound” and “of your tongue” reveal that the participants attempted to provide practical insights on effective pronunciation through descriptions of speech production. The phrase “free or tree” highlights the common strategy of comparing similar-sounding words when explaining pronunciation differences.

4.5 Concordance analysis

In the discussion, “three”, “free” and “tree” are recurring, showing that the latter two are being used as phonological substitutes for the voiceless /θ/ sound among English learners. Contributors also provide useful tips on how to pronounce /θ/, such as proper tongue positioning. These patterns demonstrate that discussions combine phonological comparison, articulatory explanation, and practical pronunciation exercises.

5.0 Discussion

The analysis shows the strategies used by learners in pronouncing the word “three”. Some learners adopt “free” or “tree” for ease, showing the relationship between /θ/, /f/, and /t/ sounds. Articulatory descriptions, such as airflow movement and tongue positioning, were chosen by contributors for explanations. Contributors also offer advice from a personal approach rather than from formal texts, indicative of a peer-to-peer learning environment. Also, the words three, tree and free appear the most, indicating that the discussion was kept within context.

6.0 Conclusion

The study shows the use of Corpus linguistic techniques in analysing discussions about pronouncing the word three in an online English learning environment, namely frequency analysis, concordance analysis and n-gram extraction. The study showed a comparison between similar-sounding words, such as free and tree. Also, the conversation involves practical and articulatory descriptions for pronunciation and instructional language, and personal opinions are chosen rather than formal authorities.

7.0 Limitation and Further Study

The dataset is relatively small (~ 1300 words), copied from a limited number of discussion posts. Also, the dataset focused on a single pronunciation issue. Future research should involve a larger dataset and more pronunciation discussions across different online learning communities.